

much of a threat as it is for newer entrants. Probably, it's this fear that drove Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) to obliterate all other brands from Zee and Star networks for a day, a strategy called "Roadblocks". The idea delivered 100 million people to the brand for a full day exclusively. Explains Srikanth Srinivasamadhavan, general manager, Media Services, HUL: "The idea is innovative and is expected to bring stronger engagement with consumers." Critics, however, say such gimmicks work only when a brand has some specific message to convey to the viewer. When Vodafone did it, it needed to communicate a change in name. But HUL had no new message to convey.

The challenge is to attract and keep customers in a fragmented, multi-channel world. The all-out war for wallet-share can only be won by whoever wins the battle for eyeballs. Brands are realising that the remote control has truly empowered viewers, who no longer watch a commercial through if it does not fire their imagination.

As competition heats up, players are devising new ways to reach consumers. From sponsoring trains, like the Rajdhani, to providing the comfort of an air-conditioner in a bus shelter, brands are doing everything to show their solidarity with their target audience. Till early this year, Airtel and Kurkure were running Rajdhani trains, where they were in-charge of maintenance of bathrooms and housekeeping on these trains.

It's a strange dichotomy that plagues the advertising and media buying fraternity. While they have never had it so good in terms of cost per rating point, which helps them determine the price for a 10-second spot, the downside is that not much value is delivered to the advertiser due to the clutter of channels. The option is very clear before the advertiser, says Shashi Sinha, chairman of Lodestar Universal: "While the supply of television stations has grown tremendously, demand for advertis-



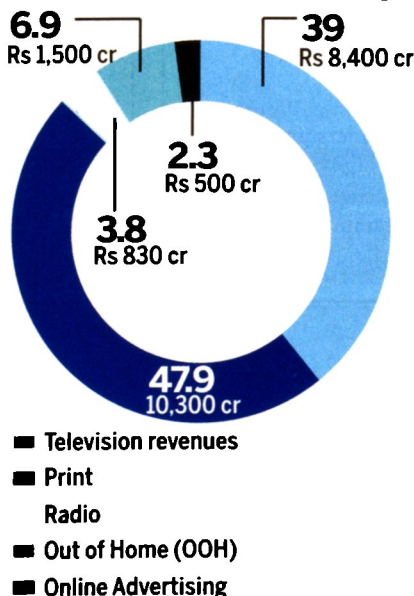
Branded Content: Programmes are conceptualised to focus on core values of brands. It could be a game-show or a reality show where the product is highlighted.

Example: *Godrej Khelo Jeeto Jiyo* contest has put the company's furniture line and other home appliances back in the reckoning. Given that only buyers of Godrej products can participate in the show, sales would obviously be impacted.

Cost per episode: Rs 20 lakh

Share CAPITAL

Revenue figures and percentage share of different segments of advertising



Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

ing has not as India still does not have large indigenous brands like China. Advertising volumes are huge but there isn't much value in it."

So brands have the option of either playing the mass volume game by being present on every possible channel or mark their presence by targeting specific properties, even if cost increases several times. One of the earliest innovations in the television space has been title sponsorship, wherein a sponsor gets to be the title sponsor of a popular reality show or a talk show for a price as high as Rs 15-20 crore per season. So be it *Vodafone presents Bigg Boss* or *Lux Perfect Bride*, the brands are comfortably attached to the names of the shows, hammering the connection deeply into the viewer's mind. Even as viewers play truant, the battle is on between advertising agencies in a bid to push frontiers of innovation.